A PRIVATE BRIEFING

# Six months of free decisions.

What to automate, what to buy, and what to leave alone before your new center opens.

Prepared for **Dr. Luis Ramos**, **Fernando Escarzaga**, and **Jesse Martinez**
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**Richard Finlay**
RGF Global Ventures LLC
(480) 532-1367
rfinlay813@gmail.com

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# Six months of free decisions.

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by **Richard Finlay**, RGF Global Ventures LLC

Your new center, targeted to open around June 2027, with the MRI signed, no staff hired, and no systems chosen. One engagement takes it from a blank page to opening day, November to May. Every operational automation decision is cheap and reversible today and will not be once the vendors are signed.

> **The free move, whatever you decide about me.** Put four terms in every vendor contract before signing: named API access to your own data, HL7 interface count and fee schedule fixed at signature, data export rights in standard formats at no charge, and DICOM query permissions for systems you authorize. Before signature these are contract terms. After signature they are hostage terms.

## The candidates, ranked by value, highest first

| # | PROCESS | RECOMMENDATION | WHY IT RANKS HERE |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Contract terms before signature | **Free** | The four terms above. They cost nothing today and cannot be reopened after signature. The only item with a hard deadline, and the one I earn nothing from. |
| 2 | Prior authorization and eligibility verification | **Build** | The largest administrative cost, and the one not asked about. Medicare Advantage 2024: 11.5% of 4.1 million denied prior auths appealed, 80.7% of those appeals overturned (KFF). 40% of 1,000 physicians surveyed staff someone exclusively for it (AMA 2025). Payer FHIR prior auth APIs required by 2027-01-01. A human signs every submission and every appeal. |
| 3 | Owner reporting, including an agent you can ask questions of | **Build** | One system, two views, and all three of you see both. Operations: studies by modality, turnaround, no-shows and open slots, authorizations waiting and appeals in flight, scanner uptime, staff hours and costs against budget. Business health, owned by the practice: collections, denials and appeals won, revenue by payer. Ask it in plain words; it answers from your own numbers. Read-only, no patient contact. |
| 4 | Scheduling: cancellation backfill | **Build, small** | UC Irvine study, 19,262 exams: 22.3% cancelled versus 2.0% no-shows, 70.2% of those cancellations patient-initiated. The empty slot is known in advance. A ranked waitlist on top of the RIS, with a per-patient rate governor for the TCPA cap. |
| 5 | Medical records: inbound requests and outbound prior studies | **Build, small** | Requests in run on a clock (HIPAA 30 days, Texas 15 business days; designed to 15): intake, identity check, deadline alerts, fee calculation, DICOM export. Priors out have no electronic link to most facilities: the agent prints the request packet with a QR-coded envelope label, tracks days outstanding, and routes the returned disc to the right patient. |

**Richard Finlay**, RGF Global Ventures LLC
(480) 532-1367 · rfinlay813@gmail.com

Live proof: **radassist.app**, used daily by Dr. Ramos

| # | PROCESS | RECOMMENDATION | WHY IT RANKS HERE |
|---|---|---|---|
| 6 | Radiology report assistance | **Build (exists)** | RadAssist, used daily by Dr. Ramos: calcium scoring, thyroid ultrasound (ACR TI-RADS), Spine MRI and CT Spine, built from his own template and rules. Next on the roadmap: voice dictation, brain, cardiac CTA (CAD-RADS). Reading the images themselves is a future item with a regulatory path, not a promise. The radiologist confirms every value and signs; nothing clinical leaves without a signature. At the center: DICOM worklist and query in, HL7 v2 ORU out to the RIS. A different build from records retrieval (row 5). Across centers: one environment under one contract, each organization in its own isolated instance (own database, keys, logins, audit log). Never one shared database. |
| 7 | Scheduling: reminders, self-scheduling, intake | **Buy (your RIS)** | Commodity, bundled into modern cloud imaging RIS products. Text reminders moved MRI no-shows from 5.1% to 3.8% in a randomized trial of 6,989 MRI patients. Real, modest, already in the box. |
| 8 | Answering patients (inbound voice) | **Buy, I integrate** | 26.5% of El Paso County residents aged 5 and over (ACS 2024) speak English less than "very well," nearly all Spanish speakers. The riskiest thing on this list to get wrong (a chest-pain call, or Spanish the system garbles), and a funded vendor category. I specify, evaluate, integrate, and supervise. |
| 9 | Billing, claims, and the eligibility feed | **Buy** | Commodity clearinghouse function, established vendor market. I do not touch the claims work, and I am not building an eligibility system. Your billing vendor already exposes the EDI 270/271 eligibility feed. Row 2 builds the thing that reads that feed and acts on it, so the four access terms belong in the billing contract too. |
| 10 | Anything that touches the image clinically | **Declined** | Not from me, not from anyone, without an FDA pathway. |

## What you own if I disappear

- The specification, written for an engineer who has never met me.
- The code specific to this center, with your configuration and your data, in a repository under your organization's account. Ownership of any product pieces of mine is settled in the contract.
- Runbooks for every operational procedure and vendor contact.
- Standard interfaces only: HL7 v2, DICOM, payer APIs, a named model vendor under its own BAA.
- Your RIS and voice vendor contracts in your name, not routed through me.

## What I recommend you do not buy from me

- A custom voice agent. Buy a vendor.
- Reminders and intake. Use the RIS.
- Anything built to resell to other centers. This center is the reference implementation and the priority; your service terms do not change if I ever take on a second site.
- Anything that touches the image clinically.

Sources: KFF, Medicare Advantage prior authorization determinations in 2024 (2026-01-28), insurer data reported to CMS, all services, not imaging-specific. AMA 2025 Prior Authorization Physician Survey, n=1,000, self-reported. CMS-0057-F, 89 FR 8758. Liu et al., J Am Coll Radiol 2017, PMID 28583321, randomized. Aijaz et al., Acad Radiol 2024, PMID 38705764, UC Irvine, single center. ACS 2024 5-year, Table B16004, El Paso County. 45 CFR 164.524. 21 U.S.C. 360j(o)(1)(A): administrative support software, including appointment schedules, claims or billing information, business analytics, and determination of health benefit eligibility, is excluded from the device definition.

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Live proof: **radassist.app**, used daily by Dr. Ramos

# What an AI agent is, and how it works in your imaging center.

## Two kinds of agent

**Workflow agent.** Works the queue in the background, inside your systems: a prior authorization, a cancelled slot filled from the waitlist, a records request. It works through your RIS and the payers' own electronic connections, not by clicking around a screen. A person on your staff approves every submission before it leaves the building.

**Owner's agent.** Text it or call it; it answers from your own numbers, never from memory. Every Monday it sends a short report in two views, operations and business health, and all three of you see both.

## The guardrails

- A person signs anything clinical and anything outbound.
- Numbers are calculated and checked, never guessed.
- HIPAA business associate agreements with every vendor that touches patient data.
- Patient data stays in the United States.

## One order through prior authorization

1. The order arrives from the referring office and lands in your RIS.
2. The agent checks coverage and whether this payer requires authorization for this study.
3. If it does, the agent assembles the request from the order and clinical notes and checks it against the payer's rules.
4. Your staff member reviews and approves. Only then does it go to the payer, electronically.
5. The agent watches the payer's decision clock and schedules the study when approval arrives.
6. If denied, it drafts the appeal for a person to review and sign.

**You will click through this yourself:** a working prior authorization demo on synthetic data, no real patients, already built. The production version is wired to your RIS and payers in Phase 4. rfinlay.github.io/imaging-priorauth-demo

Scan to follow along

## What the dates depend on

The build starts in March 2027 so everything works before you open. That holds when these are in place: a signed agreement; your vendors selected and contracted in Phase 2, one pick per system, with sandbox access to their API, HL7, and DICOM interfaces; vendor contracts and HIPAA business associate agreements signed before Phase 4, and the hosting option chosen by the end of Phase 3; test access to the payers' FHIR and EDI connections, and payer enrollment and credentialing started early enough to bill at opening; one named person on your side who approves; your expected volumes and payer mix before payer-specific design starts; and equipment delivery dates. **If one of these slips, the dates move with it, and the price does not.**

**Richard Finlay**, RGF Global Ventures LLC
(480) 532-1367 · rfinlay813@gmail.com

## What I am proposing: one engagement, five phases, $45,000, fixed fee and fixed scope

| # | PHASE | WHAT YOU SIGN OFF | WHEN | FEE | PAID |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Discovery and requirements | Requirements and Roadmap: requirements for every system, patient-flow map (order to signed report to paid claim), contract terms to demand, a make-or-buy recommendation for each requirement (met by a system you buy, or a piece I build, with a ballpark running cost for anything built), shortlist and criteria for Phase 2 | Nov to mid-Dec 2026 | **$7,000** | $4,000 at signing, $3,000 on delivery |
| 2 | Vendor and system selection | Vendor Selection Report: side-by-side comparison of the shortlisted systems in each category, weighted scoring against the Phase 1 requirements (integration readiness a named criterion), pros and concerns, 5-year total cost of ownership per option (license or subscription, implementation, interface fees, support, hardware), a recommendation; plus the contracts to sign, interface fees fixed up front. Systems: scheduling; RIS and PACS, bundled cloud system or separate RIS plus PACS (Exa is one example); prior authorization and eligibility; patient phones, IVR and AI answering; radiologist dictation; billing and clearinghouse; modality worklist, reading workstations, image sharing | Mid-Dec to Jan 2027 | **$8,000** | In full at the start of the phase |
| 3 | Design and staffing plan | Architecture, Workflow and Staffing Plan, plus Total cost of ownership and operating budget: three ways to host what I build (your cloud; hybrid; all on-site with a local AI model), each with a 3-year cost, one-time, monthly, three years; you pick | Feb 2027 | **$7,000** | In full at the start of the phase |
| 4 | Build and configure | Every system, bought and built, set up, connected and passing end-to-end tests; vendors configure their own products, I manage them, connect everything and run the tests. prior authorization automated; IT install coordinated | Mar to Apr 2027 | **$14,000** | $7,000 on March 1, $7,000 on April 1 |
| 5 | Testing, training and go-live | Signed go-live readiness, staff trained on the real systems, opening-week support | May 2027 | **$9,000** | In full at the start of the phase |
| | **Total** | **Ready for a June 2027 opening, with about a month of buffer** | **Nov 2026 to May 2027** | **$45,000** | |

**How it works.** Each phase starts only after you sign off the deliverable before it. Priced for one center, one selected system per category; another center, or a different system for another center, is quoted and approved before work starts. Running costs after the build (cloud, AI usage, texting, clearinghouse, security) are not in the $45,000: billed to the center at cost in accounts in your name, estimated in Phase 1, budgeted in Phase 3, monthly statement. If the opening date moves, the timeline moves with it; the price does not. Work outside the five phases is approved by you first and billed at $150 an hour against a retainer you top up. After opening, a support plan, separate from the $45,000: $3,000 a month for up to 20 hours (monitoring, fixes, updates to what I built, vendor coordination, a response-time promise), $150 an hour beyond, from June 2027, 12-month term with a 90-day check-in. Contracted through RGF Global Ventures LLC. RadAssist is not part of this fee.

**What I need from you, by phase.** 1: time with all three of you, Dr. Ramos, Fernando and Jesse, planned services and modalities, volumes and payer mix, the target opening date. 2: budget ranges, preferred vendors, decisions. 3: hours, roles, vendor contracts in progress. 4: signed contracts and business associate agreements, sandbox access, equipment dates. 5: staff for training, the final opening date. Throughout: one named person who approves.

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Vendor-neutral: works with whatever RIS and PACS you choose.